Ten rules for agents that listen

WRITING INSTRUCTIONS

1. **Redirect the excuse**
   BOTH
2. **Watch it fail first**
   REPO
3. **Which “don’ts” work**
   REPO, MEASURED
4. **Description = trigger**
   BOTH
5. **Ask why, then rewind**
   TALK

ARCHITECTING THE WORK

6. **Cheapen mechanics, not judgment**
   BOTH
7. **One mission per agent**
   BOTH
8. **Rulings, not stalls**
   REPO

TRUSTING WHAT AGENTS DO

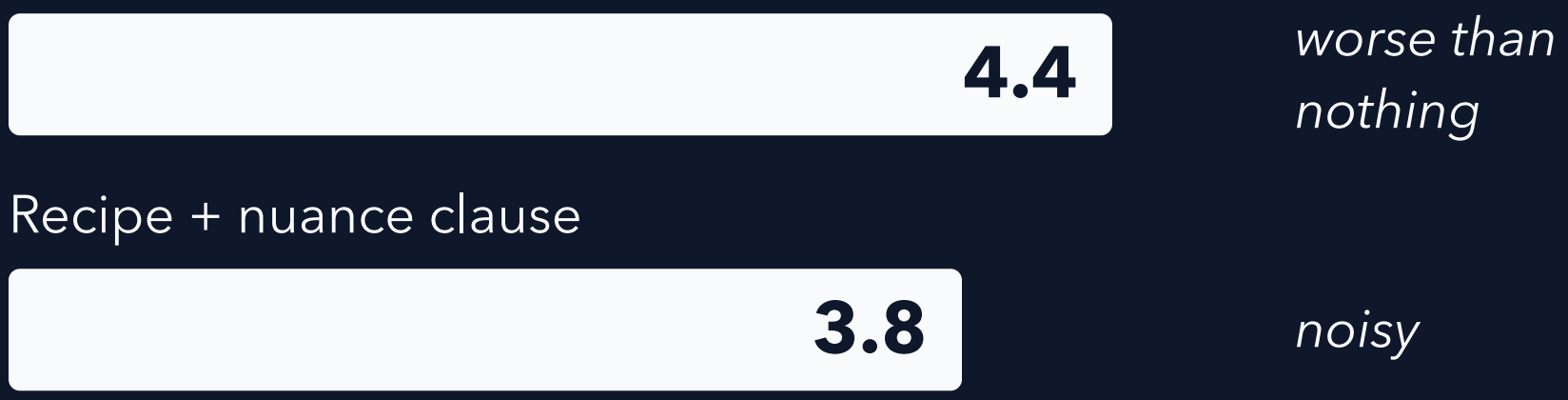
9. **Identity = a job**
   TALK
10. **“Done” isn’t done**
    BOTH

Agentics Spotlight · NYU · Nov 4, 2026 · Jesse Vincent with Amol Kapoor

Sources: Agentics Spotlight talk, 2026 · github.com/obra/superpowers, 2026

A “don’t” can be worse than nothing

Spec values the agent re-typed into its dispatch. Lower is better. Opus, 5 runs per phrasing.



But a plain rule held. ‘Do not ask reviewer to re-run tests’: 0 of 5 violations. No guidance: 3 of 5.

A ‘don’t’ about what to write fails when the model has its own agenda for the output.

Source: Superpowers, “Positive-Instruction Redesign of Skill Guidance” design spec, 2026-06-10 (micro-tests, programmatic scoring)

Jesse's rule: cheap for mechanics, never for judgment.

CODE / CHEAP MODEL
mechanics

- chunk the plan
- dispatch one agent per task
- run the scripts
- route the verdicts

TOP MODEL
six judgment calls

- why a subagent is stuck
- what a diff can't prove
- what each dispatch contains
- review verdicts and severity
- false-positive calls
- knowing the plan itself is wrong

HUMAN
four stops

- irreversible or destructive
- security-sensitive
- side effects outside the work (merge, push, publish)
- a plan so broken every path is a guess

Everything else: the agent decides and logs a Ruling (what · why · cost if wrong).

Per run, one test project (go-fractals), June config: ~$13. In the spec's tests, a cheaper controller let a planted defect through in 4 of 5 runs.

Sources: Superpowers strict-cost SDD design spec, 2026-06-10/11 · Superpowers subagent-driven-development skill, 2026 · Jesse Vincent, Agentics Spotlight, 2026

An assistant serves you. A colleague has a job.

	ASSISTANT	COLLEAGUE
WORKS FOR	one person	a team, and other colleagues
HAS	tasks	a job, an identity, its own credentials
MEMORY	usually a new session per conversation	one long session (the longest about six months), sorted by channel
SECRETS		stored outside its container; it's never allowed to see passwords or tokens
WHEN SOMETHING BREAKS		the PM ran a blameless postmortem

A persona, not a personality.

Source: Jesse Vincent, Agentics Spotlight, Nov 4 2026 · blog.fsck.com, Oct 2026

Steal this excuse table

EXCUSE	REALITY
“Should work now”	RUN the verification
“I’m confident”	Confidence ≠ evidence
“Agent said success”	Verify independently
“Too simple to test”	Simple code breaks. Test takes 30 seconds.
“Just this once”	No exceptions

Build yours: ask the agent why it did it, write down the excuse, write the redirect.

What does your team still leave to a prompt?

Alex Yedi

Source: Superpowers verification-before-completion and writing-skills (bulletproofing) skills, 2026